

Ureteral Evaluation Under Anesthesia

Patient Information · Mapping a narrowing of the ureter before a repair

WARWIKI

This is a close look at the ureter, the tube that carries urine from the kidney to the bladder. It is done while you are asleep. Your surgeon uses a few tests together to map exactly where a narrowing is and how long it is. This helps plan the right repair.

About This Test

A narrowing (a **stricture**) in the ureter is hard to measure from the outside. So your surgeon looks at it directly while you are asleep. The exam may use **any mix** of these:

- **Ureteroscopy:** a thin camera is passed up the ureter to look inside.
- **Retrograde pyelogram:** dye is sent *up* the ureter from the bladder, and X-rays outline the channel.
- **Antegrade pyelogram:** if you have a kidney drainage tube, dye is sent *down* from above, through the narrowing.
- **Cystoscopy or cystogram:** a look inside the bladder, or X-ray pictures of it.

The goal is a clear map: where the narrowing is, how long it is, and how tight it is. If a spot looks unusual, a tiny tissue sample (a **biopsy**) may be taken, since a growth can look like a narrowing. A **stent** or kidney tube may be placed or changed at the same visit.

Is It Safe?

Yes. This is a common, low-risk exam. Most people have only a little blood in the urine, mild burning, or an ache in the side for a short time. A urine infection is uncommon. An injury to the ureter is rare.

Learn the Terms

Ureter

The tube that carries urine from the kidney to the bladder.

Stricture

A scarred, narrow spot that slows or blocks urine.

Ureteroscopy

Looking inside the ureter with a thin camera.

Retrograde pyelogram

X-rays of the ureter and kidney after dye is sent up from the bladder.

Antegrade pyelogram

X-rays after dye is sent down from a kidney drainage tube.

Nephrostomy tube

A tube that drains the kidney through the back. Dye can be given through it.

Contrast dye

A liquid that shows up white on X-ray, so the channel can be seen.

Stent

A soft tube inside the ureter that keeps it open.

Will it hurt? You are asleep, so you feel nothing during the exam. Afterward, you may have mild burning when you urinate, a dull ache in your side, or pink urine for a day or two. It is a short procedure, and you usually go home the same day.

How to Get Ready

- Follow your instructions about eating, drinking and which medicines to stop, including blood thinners.
- A **urine test** checks for infection. Any infection is treated first.
- Leave any **kidney tube or stent** in place. Arrange a ride home.

Tell your team ahead of time if you:

- Have ever had a reaction to **X-ray dye or iodine**
- Take a blood thinner, or have signs of a urine infection

What Happens During the Test

- 1 You are asleep and get antibiotics.
- 2 A thin scope is passed into the bladder. Dye is sent up the ureter while X-rays are taken. A camera may also be passed up the ureter.
- 3 If you have a kidney tube, dye may be sent down from above, to show the narrowing from both ends.
- 4 The findings are mapped. A stent or kidney tube is placed or changed if needed.

After the Test

- Drink extra water for a day or two.
- If a stent was placed, some urgency or discomfort when you urinate is normal.
- Your surgeon reviews the map with you and plans the next step.

Call the office that did your test if you have:

- A temperature of **100.4 °F (38 °C)** or higher, or chills
- Side or belly pain that is getting worse
- Burning or pink urine that lasts more than a few days

Go to an emergency department if:

- You cannot urinate
- Urine like red wine or with clots, or vomiting that will not stop
- You cannot reach the office and are worried

Three Things to Remember

1. This exam maps a narrowing of the ureter while you are asleep, so your surgeon can plan the right repair.
2. Leave any kidney tube or stent in place, and arrange a ride home.
3. Mild burning, a side ache or pink urine for a day or two is normal. Drink extra water.